

SONY ERICSSON K750i

This is the latest flagship model of Sony Ericsson's extensive mobile line-up in India. A one-line description would probably go: a tri-band GSM phone with a 2-megapixel camera, FM radio tuner and an MP3 player, with a Memory Stick Duo (MSD) card slot.

The K750i is stylish, but not overly so, making it a good phone for professionals. The buttons have decent tactile feedback, but the five-way joystick is too sensitive and results in navigation errors—until you get used to it!

The camera is perhaps its best feature, and is accompanied by a pretty decent flash. There are various digital camera options such as 4X zoom, Macro mode, night mode, a cool Panorama mode for shooting wide scenes, and even a Burst mode for capturing four shots in quick succession. In movie mode, you are offered the option of either shooting for MMS or high-quality video. Overall, the camera is excellent.

Special controls include a media button on the left, which launches either FM or your media player. On the right are volume controls that double up as zoom controls when in camera mode and as the shutter button for the camera. Above the joystick is an application button that gives you quick access to various functions. In our case, this button let us end hung games.

The speaker could have been louder, and can hardly be heard on our noisy crowded streets. You cannot listen to FM without plugging in the bundled handsfree, and you cannot set the phone to ring both via the external speaker as well as in the handsfree earphones—only when set to silent mode does it ring in the ear!

Connectivity is achieved via Bluetooth, GPRS, infra-red, and the bundled USB cable. Overall, the phone is great to use, has tons of functions, a great camera and excellent battery life of about three days normal usage. At Rs 19,995, the price may be a little steep, but the camera makes it worth it.



NOKIA 6255 (CDMA)

The Nokia 6255 is perhaps one of the best CDMA mobiles available in India. For Rs 14,995, it seems packed to the brim with features as well as two screens—an external mini screen and the internal main screen—which are standard in flip phones today.

The 6255 comes with an integrated VGA camera with flash, capable of capturing still images as well as video. It also features 5X digital zoom and a night mode, as well as a self-timer. The phone is Java capable—great for all the gamers!

The main screen is 128 x 160 pixels with 65K colours. The external mini screen supports 4K colours. The keys include a five-way joystick and a user-configurable soft-key plus standard keypad.

In terms of entertainment, apart from Java games, there's the inbuilt FM radio tuner and music player which supports MP3 and AAC files.

Connectivity options include Bluetooth, infra-red, and a high speed CDMA wireless data 1xRTT connection. There's the WAP 2.0 browser, and the Nokia PC Suite is bundled. The Li-ion battery offers between 100 to 176 hours of standby time.

Overall, this phone isn't half bad for its price, and considering that Indian CDMA consumers have long been demanding a larger variety to choose from, this is one model that takes a step in the right direction.



SAMSUNG SGH-D500

Measuring just 93.5 x 45.7 x 23.6 mm and tipping the scales at just 99 gm, the D500 is the latest head-turner from Samsung. A tri-band GPRS mobile phone, the D500 boasts of features like a slide-out keypad, MP3 playback, external speakers and a 1.3-megapixel camera with flash.

Encased in a beautiful glossy black casing, the device sports a 176 x 220 LCD that can display 262,144 colours. Apart from the screen, the front facia includes a four-way navigation key with a centre button, two soft keys, a send and hang-up key, and a cancel button. The left side of the phone has a conjoined volume control key and an IR port, while the right side has a dedicated camera key and a port to connect the external speaker. The bottom of the phone slides out to reveal the backlit 12-key numeric pad and the camera at the rear.

Connectivity options include Bluetooth, USB and SyncML apart from infra-red. Other features include video and voice recording, 64 polyphonic ring tones, SMS, EMS, MMS, e-mail, and Java 2.0.

Standard applications such as World Time, multiple alarms, Calculator, Converter, Timer, Stopwatch and Organiser (with monthly, weekly and daily views) are also available. Three Java games—*Forgotten Warrior*, *Freekick* and *Arch Angel* are pre-loaded. Memory capacity is 96 MB, shared dynamically between applications. However, there is no provision for memory expansion.

The 1.3-megapixel camera can capture stills at a maximum resolution of 1280 x 1024, and has three different quality settings. The shooting mode can be set to single, multi, mosaic or night. The ISO setting can be kept at Auto, or set to speeds of 100, 200 or 400.

The flash can be switched off or set to Auto, Permanently On, or Shoot-Only modes. Video can be captured in 3gp format at a maximum of 176 x 144 pixels, again with three quality options.

In terms of usability, the phone provides a standard icon-based menu, accessible using the soft-key and the navigation button.

The size of the keys is a bit of an issue, and you'll have to use the tips of your thumbs to operate the device. The slider can be operated easily using one hand. The 262K colour screen is vibrant. MP3 playback is quite decent using the inbuilt speaker, and is even better with the external speaker module. Battery life is average at best, with the internal battery lasting between two and three days.

On the whole, the phone is great for users who want a sleek model. Price? Just Rs 21,399!

